

BY JOE MARUSAK
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Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville has launched the public phase of an \$11.6 million campaign to expand its public educational offerings and care for injured birds of prey.

The non-profit center, in Latta Plantation Nature Preserve, is among just a handful in North America dedicated to the conservation of raptors. Its science education programs reach at least 27,000 students each year. Its raptor trail and environmental education center annually draw 35,000 or more visitors.

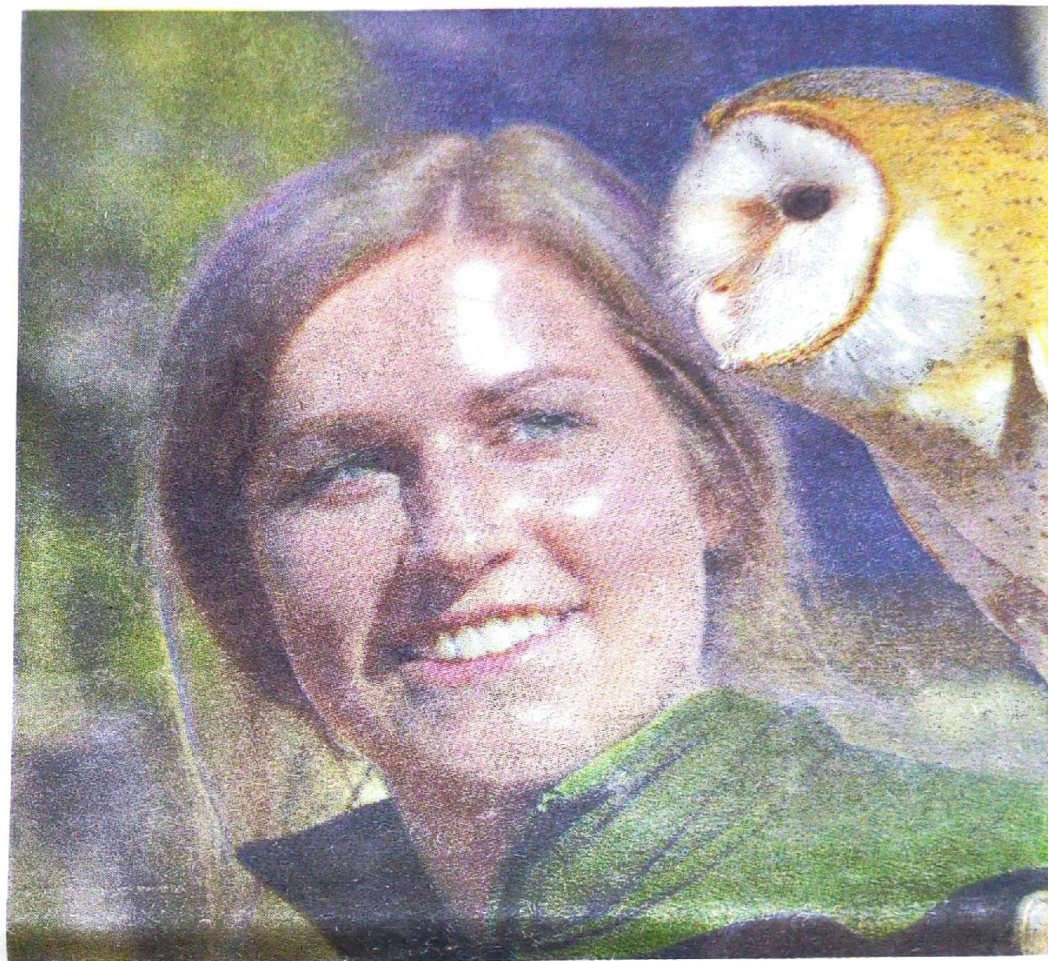
After nearly a decade of discussion, the center is partnering with Mecklenburg County Park and Recreation to create a Quest Adventure Center at the Latta Plantation Nature Preserve.

The campaign would finance a 13,000-square-foot, Mecklenburg County-owned education center, a new raptor trail system and an expanded raptor medical center.

The education center would include interactive exhibits focused on the ecosystem at Mountain Island Lake; expanded indoor-outdoor learning spaces with year-round programming; increased administrative space for staff and volunteers; and improvements for visitors including a 1,000-square-foot gift shop.

The new trail system would feature a modern resident bird care facility and exhibit, aviaries for more than 35 raptor species, and an amphitheater.

Money from the "Our



DAVID H.

Colleen Roddick, a trainer with the Carolina Raptor Center, with "Willow," a barn owl.

WILDLIFE

Raptor Center to boost care, offerings

Quest" campaign also would increase space at the center's medical facility for treating injured birds of prey, including eagles, owls and hawks.

Under the direction of staff veterinarian Dave Scott, more than 900 injured and orphaned raptors are treated there each year - an increased

patient load of 34 percent since 2008. About 75 percent of the raptors that live longer than 24 hours are rehabilitated and released into the wild.

"This project has been a long-held dream for all of us at Carolina Raptor Center," executive director Jim Warren said. "This is a once-in-a-generation

project that I know will have a positive impact on the community for generations to come."

Construction is scheduled to begin in early 2017, with a planned summer 2018 opening of the new center and raptor trail. Medical campus work is scheduled to begin early next year.



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The environmental
education center will be a
gateway to Latta Planta-
tion Nature Preserve,
which boasts the highest
number of visitors of any
of Mecklenburg County's
nature preserves and con-
nects almost half a million
people a year "to the nat-
ural beauty of North Car-
olina's Piedmont region,"
Warren and Jim Garages,
director of Mecklenburg
County Park and Recre-
ation said in a joint state-
ment announcing the
campaign.

The center already has
secured \$8.8 million for
the project, including a
leadership gift from the
Duke Energy Foundation

Campaign details

carolinaraptorcenter.org
/support/quest-campaign

and two "cornerstone"
donations from Charlotte
area residents

Duke Energy committed
the largest single gift in
the history of the center,
pledging \$400,000 to-
ward building the amphi-
theater, which will be
named for Duke Energy,
and to support construc-
tion of the raptor trail.

Bruce Roberts, founder
and retired president of
Falcon Metal Corp., and
his wife, Nancy, donated
\$300,000 to the cam-
paign - the largest gift
from individuals. The
Roberts began volun-
teering over 20 years ago
at the then-fledgling center.
Bruce Roberts is a
former board chair of the
organization, leads the
"Quest Chairman's Circle"
and belongs to the
"Our Quest" Campaign
Cabinet.

Ross Annable, retired
president of First Union
Securities, and his wife,
Michele, gave \$250,000.
Ross Annable has been a
financial supporter of the
organization for nearly
two decades and belongs
to the "Our Quest" Cam-
paign Cabinet.

Carolina Raptor Center
must raise an additional
\$1.8 million to build the
raptor trail and renovate
the raptor medical center.
A \$1 million endowment is
also being raised.

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